

Digital Transformations in Asian Politics: Opportunities, Challenges, and Implications for Democracy

Editor: Justin Chun-ting Ho (University of Amsterdam) and Dechun Zhang (Leiden University)

In our modern society, digital technologies, social media platforms, and artificial intelligence (AI) tools have become integral components of our daily lives, deeply embedded in our activities, with Asia at the forefront of this evolution. China leads globally in internet usage and mobile subscriptions and is emerging as a leader in AI. India is renowned for its IT services industry encompassing software development, outsourcing, and IT consulting. Japan has a long-standing reputation as a pioneer in science and technology, while Korea excels in technological innovation. Singapore is a leader in e-government, Taiwan dominates global microchip manufacturing, and several other Asian countries are making significant strides in technological advancements.

The transformative impact of digital technologies on digital politics is a contentious issue. Scholars argue that information communication and technologies (ICTs) can either undermine democracy through manipulation and control (Christensen, 2011; Golumbia, 2009) or enhance it by increasing access to information and facilitating idea exchange (Palmer & Perkins, 2012; Yang, 2009). Asia, with a strong potential for developing digital technology, exemplifies these debates. For example, China utilizes internet technology for political censorship and (nationalist) propaganda, while Chinese netizens employ various tactics to evade censorship and engage online. Taiwan has been lauded for employing digital tools in pandemic management, and Hong Kong protesters utilize mobile apps for organizing. Japanese political entities actively engage voters via social media, and South Korea's robust digital infrastructure shapes its political communication landscape.

In this sense, this special issue aims to contribute to our understanding of how technology shapes the political landscape in Asia. It offers insights into managing the challenges of

technology while harnessing its potential for positive or counter-democratic outcomes, while also exploring how these technologies can lead to positive (or counter) democratic outcomes. The Research Topic welcomes both empirical studies using qualitative, quantitative, computational, and mixed-methods approaches (inclusive of descriptive and causal studies); and theoretical pieces that have direct applications to digitalization and political landscape.

Our special issue is interested in conceptual, methodological, and empirical studies. Potential topics include, but are not limited to, the following:

- Digital Censorship and Resistance
- Political Propaganda
- Political Campaigns and Election
- Digital Tools in Crisis Management
- AI and Misinformation
- Digital Governance and Digital citizenship
- Regulation of Digital Platforms
- Mobile Technologies in Social Movements
- Cybersecurity and Political Stability
- Digital Divide and Political Inequality
- Digital Literacy and Political Empowerment
- Ethics and Privacy in Digital Technologies

Please submit your 500-word abstract (maximum) in English to both Dechun Zhang (d.zhang@hum.leidenuniv.nl) and Justin Ho (j.c.ho@uva.nl), with the subject line including "JCEA Special Issue."

Proposed Key Dates:

- Abstract Submission: November 29, 2024
- Notifications about invitations to submit full papers: December 20, 2024. (Invitations to submit a full paper do not guarantee final publication, as full manuscripts will undergo the journal's usual peer review process).

- Submission of full paper: May 30, 2025
- Expected publish date: December 10, 2025 (Winter issue)

Please note: The *Journal of Contemporary Eastern Asia* requires a charge of USD 100 (KRW 150,000) for all authors. Those who publish funded research must pay an additional USD 200 or KRW 300,000. The APC is applicable to accepted manuscripts and must be paid at the time of publication. Associate Editors of JCEA are exempt from APC for up to one publication per year. This only applies to unfunded research. For more information about the journal, refer to <https://jceasia.org/>.

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